Jimmy Lee 李兆康

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Fellow in Economics Sept 2024 – Present
Global Poverty Research Lab, Northwestern University

Visiting Scholar Jan 2025 – June 2026
Center for International Development, Harvard University

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Economics, Northwestern University 2024
M.Phil., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2017
B.SSc., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2015

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Program Evaluation
Focus—Synergies between Agriculture and Rural Education

Family Economics, Organizational Economics
Focus—Intergenerational Dynamics in Rural Household and Community Decision Making

Behavioral Economics
Focus—The Economics of Curiosity: Endogenous Model Uncertainty under Cognitive Limits

TEACHING

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University (Department median 5.3/6)
Introduction to Microeconomics (5.2, 5.4, 5.6), Introduction to Macroeconomics (5.4, 5.4), Intermediate Microeconomics (5.4), Intermediate Macroeconomics (5.7), International Trade (5.6), Economics of Nonprofit Organizations (5.8)

Teaching Assistant, The Chinese University of Hong Kong
Mathematical Methods in Economics I, II, Family Economics, Labor Economics, International Macroeconomics

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Miscategorization as an Information Friction? Activating School-Based Agricultural Education in Liberia with Parental Engagement"

(Funded by AFD Fund for Innovation in Development, USAID-DIV, Wellspring Foundation, and FAO)

Many developing countries have under-staffed agricultural extension systems, while rural households trade off children's schooling with farm labor. This paper shows schools can become cost-effective hubs tackling these dual challenges, but only if parent-school linkages are strengthened. In a three-year Liberian experiment across 197 schools, I evaluate school-based agricultural education (SBAE)—a voluntary program training science teachers to integrate inquiry-based learning with student-led school demonstration farms and home farming projects—estimating intent-to-treat effects on randomly sampled students. I cross-randomize whether to inform parents about this integrated program via promotional videos and field days. SBAE improves targeted outcomes when paired with parental engagement: students' households adopt 26–53% more yield-improving farming techniques, dropouts fall 4–5 percentage points per year, absenteeism falls 28%, and studying hours rise 22%. It is among the most cost-effective agricultural extension trials, and over twice as cost-effective for improving attendance as a conditional cash transfer benchmark. SBAE's positive training effects on teachers and students are unaltered by parental engagement. However, without parental engagement, SBAE's diffusion mechanisms—parents' learning from school farms, home projects, intra-household communication—stay muted. Technology adoption effects vanish, absenteeism rises 31%, studying hours fall 20%, and parents disconnect: only a third of parents visit school farms in three years, visit frequency falls 12%, and parent–teacher meetings fall 39%. Parents' persistent avoidance of information, plus sharply reversed responses under engagement, pose a puzzle. Bayesian updating, selective attention, and associative memory each fall short. I propose an integrative explanation: parental engagement shifts parents away from viewing agriculture and education as substitutes.

WORKING PAPERS

1. **"Technology Adoption and Schooling as Complements: The Promise of School-Based Agricultural Education in Africa"** (joint with Christopher Udry)

In sub-Saharan Africa, wide heterogeneity across farms makes other households' experience a noisy guide to what suits a household's own farms, slowing technology diffusion, while low perceived returns to schooling drive students to drop out. We develop a model of why school-based agricultural education (SBAE), a holistic program in which trained science teachers integrate inquiry-based learning with student-led school demonstration farms and home farming projects, addresses this dual problem. Our model builds on the target-input framework, in which a household learns a technology's suitability only by using it in production or by observing others who do. We add a third channel: the more of a child's time the household devotes to schooling, the more precisely it learns from the school's production signals. Schooling and technology adoption become complements. First, schooling carries an option value on the farm: by raising the probability of future adoption, it makes attendance worthwhile even where labor-market returns are low. Second, SBAE effectively subsidizes information acquisition by delivering information through schooling, whose cost households already bear for its educational returns, countering the under-supply of information in the presence of learning spillovers. We provide experimental evidence from Liberia that SBAE cost-effectively raises both agricultural technology adoption and school attendance, and use extensions of the model to study how SBAE's design can be strengthened, including (i) how effectively inquiry-based learning raises the marginal informational return to schooling, and (ii) how effectively SBAE's home visits aggregate households' dispersed knowledge and feed it back to them.

2. **"Endogenous Model Uncertainty and Curiosity under Cognitive Limits"**

   What is curiosity: what leads a person to seek the information required to explore new perspectives? Neuroscience suggests that people automatically classify a situation before choosing how to act, drawing a familiar interpretation from similar past situations (e.g., a farmer attributing a neighbor's high yield to good weather). As observations become harder to reconcile with that interpretation, people entertain alternatives. This paper treats such shifts in "mindsets" as a choice of how much model uncertainty to entertain. Each mental model pairs a prior with a view of how observable features combine to reveal the state. After an initial signal, an agent with a costless default and latent alternatives jointly chooses model weights and how much information to acquire. The key discipline is an evidence constraint that bounds motivated beliefs: an alternative's weight is capped by its Bayesian posterior. Curiosity then arises endogenously as the value of resolving the model uncertainty the agent chooses to entertain. Because agents can seek information and reason beyond what associative memory supplies, exploration is both triggered and tested by evidence, which revises hallmark behavioral effects in memory-based models (e.g., Bordalo et al. 2023, 2026). Payoff-irrelevant contextual cues open a new perspective only when they activate an alternative under which they matter, and the curiosity this stimulates tests that perspective, so the shift lasts only if evidence supports it. Yet cues consistent with several alternatives can stifle exploration by dividing the evidence among them, even when each alternative outperforms the default. Development examples illustrate how to stimulate curiosity about innovative programs, pedagogies, and farming techniques.

3. **"Can Communicating Parents' Beliefs to Students Be a Pivotal Component of Parental Engagement? Evidence from School-Based Agricultural Education in Liberia"**

   (Funded by NSF, Weiss Fund, Global Poverty Research Lab, and the Buffett Institute for Global Affairs)

   When school programs require students to introduce improved techniques on household farms, is informing students and parents about the program sufficient, or is there a case for further signaling parents' support to students? I study this question within a randomized evaluation of school-based agricultural education (SBAE) in Liberia, where students take school farm training into a home farming project. After parents view a promotional video of the program and students are encouraged to diffuse techniques to their parents, I randomize a nudge revealing to students their parents' optimism about their farm-management skills. Two years later, SBAE improves students' livelihoods only with the nudge: income rises 63%, on-time school fee payment 43–47%, and cost-effectiveness for attendance doubles. Analysis of mechanisms highlights a management aspect of agricultural technology adoption that can be addressed with nudges: even where parents become attentive to SBAE and adopt promoted techniques, third-party assurance can be pivotal in shifting students away from assisting in subsistence farming.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Ongoing Randomized Experiments (scaling SBAE across Liberia, Côte d'Ivoire, and Kenya in 2026-35)

1. **"Learning to Learn: Synergizing Inquiry-based Science and Agricultural Transformation in Liberia"** (joint with Vesall Nourani, Harvard GSE; scheduled RCT within the scaling of SBAE in 2026-29)
2. **"Parental Engagement in School-based Agricultural Education: Testing Mechanisms at Scale"** (piloted interventions in 2025-26)
3. **"School-based Agricultural Education, Parental Engagement, and the Use of Unconditional Cash Transfers"**
4. **"Directed Technical Change under Data-Driven Farming Advice: An Empirical Framework"** (grant from Weiss Fund; piloted survey method; planning RCT)

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Total program evaluation and academic research grants secured for SBAE in Liberia: **$4.2 million**

Program Evaluation Grants

AFD Fund for Innovation in Development ($1.2 mil; co-PI) 2025

J-PAL Learning for All Initiative: Scaling Award ($222K; co-PI) 2024
USAID Development Innovation Ventures ($395K; co-PI) 2022
Wellspring Foundation ($192K; co-PI) 2022
AFD Fund for Innovation in Development ($1.2 mil; co-PI) 2021
Food and Agriculture Organization ($68K; co-PI) 2021

Academic Research Awards

J-PAL Learning for All Initiative ($400K; co-PI) 2025
Weiss Fund ($5K; Lead PI) 2022
National Science Foundation ($451K; co-PI) 2020
Weiss Fund ($29K; Lead PI) 2020
Global Poverty Research Lab ($19K; Lead PI) 2019
Buffett Institute for Global Affairs ($5K; Lead PI) 2019

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

During postdoctoral studies:

Mundlak Workshop in Agricultural and Applied Economics (scheduled); National Chung Cheng University; NYU Africa House–Center for Technology, Economics, and Development (CTED); Mohammed VI Polytechnic University (UM6P); Tel Aviv University; Oklahoma State University; Harvard Center for International Development; Africa Food Systems Forum 2024

During PhD:

Meeting of the Society of Economics of the Household (SEHO); J-PAL—Middle East and North Africa (MENA); CGIAR—Standing Panel on Impact Assessment (SPIA); International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI); University of Glasgow; National Graduate Institute for Policy Studies (GRIPS, Tokyo); Development Day 2023

LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

Citizenship: Hong Kong Special Administrative Region, China
Languages: English (fluent), French (intermediate), Mandarin (fluent), Cantonese (native)
Programming: Stata, R, Matlab, Python, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

REFERENCES

Professor Christopher Udry (Chair)
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